

Work from Home & Job Satisfaction: A Study Review for a Post-Pandemic World

Jennèa Jeter

Department of Psychology: Rowan College at Burlington County

PSY-259-1050: Social Psychology

Elizabeth Lavertu

July 18, 2024

After the initial rise of the COVID-19 pandemic in March 2020, every aspect of work life was impacted. By 2021, over 700,000 establishments had to close temporarily or permanently to avoid the spread, losing crucial jobs and incomes (Decker & Haltiwanger, 2022). With 3.4 billion people locked inside, the call for telework solutions became louder and louder (Niebuhr et al., 2022). As various companies and organizations create their interpretations of the work-from-home (WFH) model, it is crucial to understand the benefits and drawbacks of different styles. Further research in this field will empower individuals to make informed decisions regarding remote telework and create solutions for potential problems.

Telework is the practice of workers having a portion or most of their hours away from the workplace. People who use this method rely on technology to complete collaborative or solo tasks and benefit from choosing their location (Allen et al., 2015). The term was coined by Jack Nillies in 1973, and by 1979, the first WFH experiment was done through IBM testing when the company sent five people to use the equipment for telework. The experiment continued into the 80s as technology and strategies advanced. Thanks to this project at IBM, a framework for

telework was created, and the company modified its motto to "work is something you do, not something you travel to" (Nillies, 2013).

Conducted during the pandemic, this literature review examines a study on work ability, stress-related physical and psychological symptoms, and overall job satisfaction in WFH placements. Moreover, it examines the workers' relationships to technology and autonomy during telework. The findings of this research can enhance the analysis of modern telework practices and see what improvements can be made in a world post-COVID.

Niebuhr, Borle, Börner-Zobel, and Voelter-Mahlknecht (2022) wanted to examine WFH satisfaction in German employees during the pandemic. The six hypotheses analyzed five factors that impacted work ability, psychological and physical stress symptoms, and job satisfaction. The factors included the percentage of time spent in the home office (Factor 1), technology functionality (Factor 2), company agreement on remote work (Factor 3), employer flexibility with WFH (Factor 4), and increased autonomy experience (Factor 5).

1. Hypothesis 1 (H1) states that Factor 1 would negatively impact work ability and psychological and physical stress symptoms.
2. Hypothesis 2 (H2) states that Factor 1 would positively impact ability and psychological and physical stress symptoms instead.
3. Hypothesis 3 (H3) states that Factor 2 would positively affect work ability, psychological and physical stress symptoms, and job satisfaction.
4. Hypothesis 4 (H4) states that Factor 3 would positively affect work ability, psychological

and physical stress symptoms, and job satisfaction.

5. Hypothesis 5 (H5) states that Factor 4 would positively affect work ability, psychological and physical stress symptoms, and job satisfaction.

6. Hypothesis 6 (H6) states that Factor 5 would positively affect work ability, psychological and physical stress symptoms, and job satisfaction.

The study was done during the "lockdown light" phase of the German pandemic status, where 14% of German employees worked at home. Over 500 people were selected through a panel company from various industries to complete a three-part survey. The first part is that the participants had to be employed in Germany with a calculated work-from-home percentage.

The

questions given measured work-from-home time, equipment and technology functionality, autonomy, WFH agreement timing, and flexibility granted by employers.

Each participant's overall level of work ability was assessed using the Work Ability Index's (WAI) Work Ability Score (WAS). This score was calculated on a sliding scale of 0 to 10, with 0 being unable to work and 10 being working at best condition. The physical symptoms were also measured using the Burnout Bullying Inventory, which uses a 1-5 scale, with 1 being does not apply and 5 being fully applies.

The study had several interesting results contradicting and supporting some of their previous information on WFH. The study revealed that higher percentages of remote work (Factor 1) could increase stress-related symptoms and reduce job satisfaction. This finding

contradicts the belief that working from home only enhances job satisfaction. Still, the percentage of hours worked from home impacted employees' psychological and physical symptoms but did not affect work ability.

Factor 2 (technology functionality), Factor 3 (company agreement on remote work), and Factor 5 (experience of increased autonomy) significantly predicted job satisfaction. The study emphasizes that the impact of adequate equipment on outcomes with technical functionality was the main predictor of work ability. Workers with good equipment had a 77% satisfaction rate compared to 31% without the necessary technology. Work autonomy, real or perceived, also increased job satisfaction, which is a finding that can be used in both in-person and telework. Work-from-home agreements (Factor 3) were surprisingly related to more stress symptoms. Since the study did not analyze the types of agreements or quality, this factor remains to be investigated more. With autonomy impacting work satisfaction, contracts promoting flexibility and communication with the employee may provide less strenuous effects.

Niebuhr, Borle, Börner-Zobel, & Voelter-Mahlknecht's study is a stepping stone in a vast and evolving field of work. Understanding that this experiment was done during the COVID-19 pandemic is essential. With a global crisis happening in the background of everyone's lives, stress results will have an overall impact on the study, making it crucial to interpret the data with caution. With that, Germany's handling of the pandemic was much different than that of the United States. While Germany had around 44 million workers in 2022, America had 160 million (Statista, 2024). This larger population impacted the job field and the overall lockdown. Americans did not have a lockdown light status, meaning that WFH was the only path other than

unemployment for many. Researchers must consider the unprecedented circumstances and the policy differences as potential effects on mental health, allowing for a deeper understanding of how external factors can amplify stress levels and influence behavior.

While remote work offers flexibility and convenience, it also presents challenges such as isolation, blurred work-life boundaries, and potential burnout. To address these issues, implementing structured support systems and clear communication channels, can help mitigate the long-term impacts of such crises. Companies are also encouraged to offer flexible options that cater to diverse needs, including hybrid models that combine remote and in-office work. Ultimately, the research on WFH can be used to create a balanced and sustainable telework ecosystem that promotes productivity without compromising employee health and happiness. Through collective effort and compassionate understanding, we can build a more resilient society capable of redefining and designing a future that all workers will enjoy.

References

Niebuhr, F., Borle, P., Börner-Zobel, F., & Voelter-Mahlknecht, S. (2022). Healthy and happy working from home? effects of working from home on Employee Health and Job Satisfaction. *International Journal of Environmental Research and Public Health*, 19(3), 1122.

<https://doi.org/10.3390/ijerph19031122>

Nilles, J. (2013, January 15). *What's Telework?* JALA International: Telework and telecommuting definitions. <https://www.jala.com/definitions.php>

Statista Research Department, & 5, J. (2024, July 5). *Employed individuals seasonally adjusted U.S. 2024*. Statista.

<https://www.statista.com/statistics/209123/seasonally-adjusted-monthly-number-of-employees-in-the-us/#:~:text=U.S%20seasonally%20adjusted%20monthly%20number%20of%20employees%202022%2D2024&text=In%20May%202024%2C%20about%20161.08,employed%20in%20the%20United%20States.> Uy,
M. (2021, March 10). *Telecommuting versus telework*. Lifewire.
<https://www.lifewire.com/difference-between-telecommuting-and-telework-2378090>